CHAPTER 6

LAL MASJID OPERATION, ESCALATION IN TERRORIST ACTIVITIES AND EXPANSION ACROSS THE COUNTRY

Shortly before the formal launching of TTP in December 2007, there was a manifold escalation in terrorist activities that terrified the people of Pakistan. In 2005, only four terrorist activities were recorded, in which 84 people were killed; in 2006, the number increased marginally as seven such activities were recorded killing 163 people. However, in 2007, there was a meteoric rise in terrorism as 54 terrorist activities were recorded killing 760 people. This situation became severe as the subsequent years witnessed a further escalation in terrorism. The main reason behind this surge in terrorism and violence, which was also considered by some as the reason for the formal birth of TTP, was the army operation on 'Lal Masjid' (Red Mosque) situated in the heart of the capital of Pakistan, Islamabad.[1]

The Pakistan Army's 111 Brigade and Special Services Group commandoes launched an operation, codenamed Operation 'Sunrise' against the clerics and students of Lal Masjid, Islamabad, on 16 July 2007. The Lal Masjid and the adjacent Madrasah Hafsa were besieged from 3 July to 11 July 2007, while negotiations were attempted between the militants and the cabinet ministers Ch. Shujaat Hussain and Ijaz-ul-Haq. Once negotiations failed, the complex was stormed and captured by the Pakistan Army's Special Service Group. The conflict ended with